22 – Legal & compliance

Definition: Legal & compliance covers the ground rules that apply when using AI in everyday life: data protection (GDPR), copyright, labeling requirements and the responsibility that stays with you.

> **Remember:** The AI does the work, the responsibility stays with you.

Important: This cheatsheet is not legal advice. It offers orientation for everyday use. The legal situation keeps evolving; if in doubt, ask an expert or the data protection officer of your organization.

Key points

- **GDPR (data protection, German: DSGVO): Personal data** is anything that can be linked to a person (name, address, photos, often also email addresses). **Rule:** other people's personal data does not belong in an AI chat, especially on free plans, where inputs may be used for training (topic 04). **Data processing on behalf of others** (German legal term: "Auftragsverarbeitung") means: anyone who processes data on behalf of an organization needs a contractual basis for doing so – for work devices and work data, the employer's rules apply.
- **Copyright:** Uploading **your own content** (texts, images) can affect the rights to it – check who owns them and what the service's terms of use say. Don't upload **other people's content** (e.g. protected texts or photos) without permission. **AI output:** whether and for what purposes you may use AI-generated output under intellectual property law is partly unresolved – be careful with important works (a book, a logo) and get expert advice.
- **Labeling:** EU rules require transparency for certain AI applications (e.g. AI-generated images, chatbots). Platform and employer rules also apply. **Practical rule:** if the origin is not clearly recognizable, label the AI-generated parts.
- **Responsibility:** The AI can make mistakes (topic 08). If you publish or send something, you are responsible for it – "the AI wrote it" is no excuse.
- **Exams, school, university:** Every institution has its own rules about where and how AI may be used. Those rules apply, even if the service itself allows it.

Example

You want to evaluate a members list for your club (fictional: "Example Club"):

Step	Legal aspect	Safe way
Load the members list into the tool	other people's personal data (names, addresses)	Anonymize the list: "Member A", "Member B" (topic 04)
Have statistics created	no personal individual data needed	Only have aggregated numbers evaluated
Use the result in the newsletter	labeling for AI-generated text parts	Briefly mark it: "Created with AI assistance"
Keep the members list in the chat	the history may be stored	Delete the chat after the task, check the training usage

The evaluation works just as well with anonymized data – without legal risk for you or the club.

Do / Don’t

Do	Don’t
Anonymize other people’s personal data	Dump address or customer lists into the chat
Label AI-generated parts where it isn’t obvious	Pass AI output off as entirely your own work
Check your employer’s and institution’s rules	Use private AI accounts for company data
Ask an expert when unsure	“Settle” legal questions with a chatbot

Safety note

No personal data, nothing confidential, no third-party copyrighted content in the chat – this applies especially to free plans. Your employer’s rules always take precedence.

Mini checklist

- ☐ I can explain what personal data is.
- ☐ I don’t upload other people’s data without anonymizing it.
- ☐ I know the AI rules of my institution and my employer.
- ☐ I know that responsibility for the output stays with me.
- ☐ When legal questions come up, I get expert advice instead of asking the AI.

Exercise (5 min.)

Take one of your own use cases (e.g. a club, a side job, a term paper): What data appears in it? Which of it would be personal data? How would you anonymize it before it goes into a chat?

Next

- Extra exercises: `02_extra_exercises/22_extra_exercises`
- Test: Test F (Final)
- Related: 04 Data privacy in everyday life, 08 Hallucinations, 13 Guardrails, 23 Everyday workflows

As of: October 2026